Canoe Valley School

PROGRAM GUIDE

Thank you for your interest in Canoe Valley School! We're glad this guide has found you. What follows is an overview of our vision, our one-of-a-kind learning program, our campus, and some of the unique features of our school. We also include enrollment details for families ready to take the next step and join our pre-enrollment waitlist.

OUR MISSION

Canoe Valley School aims to support students as they cultivate their whole selves, and their connection to place, in order that they might find their path in life and proceed boldly, with creativity, care and competency. Students, teachers, parents, and community members pursue this work together through self-directed, relational learning, and as a whole the school community aims to serve the place we live, and to create a more beautiful, just, and abundant world.

Our Vision

We are an emerging secondary school in rural Winneshiek County, located on a 40-acre campus tucked away in a lush tributary valley of Canoe Creek. Our vision for education is both old and new, drawing on longstanding alternative educational traditions like Waldorf and Montessori, but also arising from the educational history of this place and from the people who have come together to found the school. Above all we aim to help students grow as whole persons, supporting their self-motivation, self-understanding, healthy relationships, and sense of responsibility and purpose, in addition to their knowledge foundations. We pay particular attention to students' connection to place, believing that strengthening our relationship to the natural world and to community leads to the deepest kind of learning, and to a more just and abundant world.

Canoe Valley's thoughtfully designed learning program pursues these goals using an approach we call self-directed learning, together, in which student curiosity and agency drives a project-based curriculum, and teachers spark, inspire and deepen learning. Peers, parents, community members, and the natural world are close companions in the learning process. Our program offers abundant opportunities for exploration and play outdoors, shared outdoor work, as well as occasions for deep attention, mindfulness/contemplative reflection, and healthy relationship building.

We provide a high-quality foundation in core skills and knowledge, as well as in-depth and customizable preparation for college and other post-secondary pathways. We take an interdisciplinary, whole-person and place-based approach to academic subject areas, and offer supplemental programs in reading and math. Co-curricular offerings include a mentorship program, apprenticeship opportunities, student participation in school committees and governance, and much more.

For more on our educational values and methods, please see the Educational Vision section of our Long Range Plan.

Enrollment

Basic details about our timeline and about how to enroll at Canoe Valley School.

We are welcoming enrollment interest from families of students aged 12-18 for our anticipated fall 2027* opening. We are planning on a first-year enrollment size of about 15 students, and aim to grow within a few years to about 30-40 students in two mixed-age

programs, a lower and an upper level. Our enrollment application will be available this coming fall/winter; we anticipate significant interest, so please consider joining our pre-enrollment waitlist. If we receive more applications than we have spots available, we will prioritize applications in order of pre-enrollment waitlist sign-up date.

In line with our core institutional value of accessibility (see Institutional Characteristics below), we aim to make enrolling at Canoe Valley School as affordable and flexible as we can. Upon accreditation, we will be able to offer families access to the State of Iowa's Educational Savings Account (ESA) program to offset tuition. To ensure the financial stability and institutional thriving of the school, and in light of the financial picture reported by families in the feasibility study included in our Long Range Plan, tuition will also include an annual supplement paid by families in addition to ESA per-pupil funding, set at an accessible level. We are currently exploring scholarship as well as sliding-scale options for the tuition supplement for families in financial need.

The school is also exploring at least one flexible schedule enrollment option: a half-time schedule that would allow students to pursue part of their education at home or at another institution, part at Canoe Valley, and if a high school diploma is desired, to graduate from either Canoe Valley or another institution. Note that this option would not include access to the ESA program, which requires at least 75% full-time enrollment. Note also that the advancement pathway we are exploring for half-time students will depend on accreditor approval.

*Founding a new school is a complex undertaking, and while a fall 2027 opening remains our goal, our opening date will be shaped by many factors including enrollment, site development, and accreditation.

Institutional Characteristics

Who we are as an institution. For more, see the Institutional Vision section of our Long Range Plan.

In many ways Canoe Valley School will operate as a traditional non-public secondary school. We are a non-profit educational organization offering a comprehensive secondary-level learning program, and will be an accredited, diploma-granting institution offering support for college admissions as well as for non-traditional post-secondary pathways. Canoe Valley is currently a candidate for accreditation with the Middle States Association of Colleges and Schools.
There are also a number of institutional features that make us unique. We have a multi-stakeholder board designed to equally represent the interests of parents, teachers, students, and community members. The school will be led by Teacher-Administrators: full- and part-time educators jointly sharing responsibility for the academic, cultural, and operational life of the institution. The school will also employ other teachers on a part-time basis without, or with limited, administrative duties, as well as Session Teachers who teach electives and/or serve as guest teachers on an intermittent basis.

Students will have the opportunity to participate meaningfully in school management and governance, including committee work connected to school operations and culture.

The school emphasizes partnership with other alternative-education institutions and allied organizations in the community and region, and serves as a hub and anchor institution for work of a similar spirit in the Canoe Creek Watershed, greater Decorah area, northeast Iowa, and the Driftless region.

The institution is grounded in the educational values discussed below, as well as in institutional values including interdependence and accessibility, shared leadership, relational autonomy, meaningful work, and adaptive institutional learning.

Educational Values and Methods

The why and how of education at Canoe Valley. For more, see the Educational Vision section of our Long Range Plan.

We are crafting a form of whole-person education that is both new and inspired by longstanding alternative-educational traditions, including Waldorf, Montessori, Reggio Emilia, and the approach to education championed by John Dewey. We are also part of an alternative educational lineage rooted right here in northeast Iowa, including the area's decades-long history of homeschooling, Northeast Iowa Montessori,

Kinderhaus preschool, and the Pleasant Valley School. In particular we take inspiration from whole-person educational models that aim to draw out the one-of-a-kind qualities and purposes of each individual, in relationship to others and to the natural world. In practical terms, whole-person learning means supporting human development beyond the intellect alone. We aim to support capacities or potentials like self-motivation, self-expression, and relational ability, each of which involves our full experience, including the way we think, feel, sense, intuit, and so on.

Our approach is unique in going a bit deeper than whole-person education sometimes does in naming and imagining specific capacities, or areas of human potential, that we want to support, and crafting a curriculum that arises from them. Each of these is also an educational value unto itself: a core good that expresses what we think education is for, and that guides our learning and teaching in its own way. The Educational Vision section of our Long Range Plan goes into much more detail on each one:

- ***Self-Motivation and Engagement:*** How we follow our curiosity and persevere in what comes of it; how we show up to the learning process and to our efforts more generally.
- ***Self-Understanding and Expression:*** How we discover who we are, come to know and affirm ourselves and share that with the world.
- ***Relational Capacity and Interdependence:*** How we find mutual support and kinship with others across difference.
- ***Connection to Place:*** How we cultivate connection with the more-than-human world and belonging in community.
- ***Knowledge Foundations:*** How we come to know the world, and cultivate skills that will sustain us in it.
- ***Responsibility and Purpose:*** How we offer something meaningful back to the world that has shaped us, and how we shape it in turn.

These six areas are far from exhaustive in terms of the various human potentials that education can support. But as aims, they are well supported by research and align with the values of families we aim to serve (see for example the results of our fall 2025 survey in our Long Range Plan).

How do we support these areas of development in our students? If whole-person learning centers on fostering our innate curiosity and desire to learn, and on our unique identities, then the educational experience we provide needs to be meaningfully self-directed. It needs to provide expansive freedom for students to learn in a way that derives from their own agency and reflects who they are. On the other hand, if whole-person learning happens in meaningful relationship with others, with the natural world, and within communities, and is oriented toward responsibility and purpose in a broader social context, it needs to go beyond self-directed learning alone.

A great deal of balancing and interweaving is necessary, in other words, between learning that is freely self-directed by students as individuals, and learning that is structured, inspired, activated, provoked by others: by teachers, parents, mentors, and the local community, as well as shaped by external validating institutions like colleges, the state Department of Education, and our accreditor. These are the considerations that have guided us as we put our values into practice, and lead us to a model we call self-directed learning, together.

Self-directed learning, together is a hybrid approach that balances student-led learning with teacher-initiated (and other adult-initiated) educational experiences, peer learning, and participation in school culture and community life. Students shape their own learning goals, projects, and pathways, while also engaging in interdisciplinary, project-based curriculum designed by teachers and linked to core competencies. This balancing of student and adult leadership in learning is understood as a productive tension that guides practice rather than a problem to be resolved.

The next section introduces our curriculum and gives a sense of how this balance plays out in practice.

Curriculum Overview

What follows is a summary of the components of our curriculum. For a more detailed look, see our Curriculum Handbook.

CORE CURRICULUM

1. Self-Directed, Project-Based Learning

Students at Canoe Valley have substantial freedom to make things and develop projects according to their interests and lived experience, as well as pursue and adapt teacher-designed projects. The ebb and flow between student-designed and teacher-designed/ student-adapted projects is a core component of what we mean by self-directed learning, together. We view this as a productive tension that evolves as students progress through the program, with students taking on increasing freedom and responsibility in directing their own learning as they advance from the lower to the upper level.

We use the word project to describe the core form of educational activity that students do at the school. Projects take the place of traditional core classes; are interdisciplinary, weaving together multiple core subject areas; and range in scope and duration, from large-scale efforts taking weeks or at times even months (a seed saving project, a watershed stewardship effort, a student-run magazine) to smaller projects completed in a few days or less (an observation-to-hypothesis lab, a group music-making project). For the typical longer-duration project, a 3-4 week cycle is about average, during which time shorter duration projects may run concurrently.

Teachers at Canoe Valley aim above all to provide a relational spark, inspiration, and provocation for student learning, modeling lived relationships to areas of knowledge about which they are passionate. Teachers design rich interdisciplinary and place-based projects for students to explore and adapt, as well as brief, provocative learning experiences (mini-lessons, demonstrations, field trips) that introduce and support project work. Teachers also collaborate as educational mentors with students as they design their own projects, individually and with peers. To kick-start all of this, teachers provide a mini-course at the start of each year in the school's form of self-directed, project-based learning, with updates throughout the year.

Families and community members are partners in this process, invited to take interest in student projects, share skills or community connections, and share in the school's educational values and culture.
We understand the place we live–our beautiful campus and wild and storied rural neighborhood–as the foundation of all of this, and our project-based curriculum is carefully designed to interweave it into just about everything we do.

See the Curriculum Handbook for more.

2. Competency Pathways

In the core curriculum (as opposed to activities 'beyond the core curriculum' discussed below, also see our Sample Schedule below), student projects meaningfully engage with foundational subject-area knowledge and a focused and distilled set of core skills. How this happens for each student at each level is what we call a competency pathway. Early on, students pursue teacher-initiated projects already aligned to core competencies (we use the term "competencies" to refer to core skills and knowledge), with significant room for customization. As they progress, students have opportunities to self-design projects from the ground up, working with teachers to align them to subject-area competencies. In the upper level, many or most projects are student self-designed in collaboration with teachers, with students' intended post-secondary paths in mind. See the Curriculum Handbook for more.

In addition to subject-area requirements, all competency pathways also build in semesterly collaboration and service-learning requirements.

3. Subject Areas

We take an open-ended, interdisciplinary approach to core subjects, framing each as an area of activity rather than simply an area of content. Our seven subject areas are:

- ***Communication Arts:*** How do the languages and stories around us bring us into meaningful relationship with the world, and vice versa?
- ***Math and Spatial Reasoning:*** How do we discover and employ the patterns that order the world around us?
- ***Social Sciences and Community Life:*** How do

people create meaning, belonging, and shared life together?

- ***Science and Ecological Arts:*** How do our methods of questioning and investigation guide us into deeper relationship with the plants, animals, materials, and systems we share the world with?
- ***Practical Life and Wellness:*** How does one live a healthy, embodied, and fulfilling life?
- ***Fine and Practical Arts:*** How do imagination and craft work together to create meaningful and beautiful expressions?
- ***Appropriate Design and Technology:*** How do we create tools, technologies, and spaces that support greater flourishing in the world?

In line with our values, we specify content areas in each subject that emphasize both traditional foundations and new approaches to disciplinary knowledge. For instance, Communication Arts includes reading, writing, and verbal expression, but also deep listening, reflection, and media studies/production. Science and Ecological Arts includes the life, earth, and physical sciences, but pairs these with naturalist knowledge, stewardship skills, and nature-based arts (which our rural campus will offer abundant opportunities to practice!).

4. Documenting Learning

Learning is documented in multi-media portfolios of student work, accompanied by a learning narrative written by students and teachers. Students comment on their own growth, challenges, and evolving relationship to the learning process. Teachers offer comments on student growth in each of the school's six developmental areas. In five of the six areas, these comments are observational and mostly non-evaluative in nature. In the sixth, Knowledge Foundations, teachers provide brief, growth-oriented evaluations of students' developing fluency in the school's core competencies.

5. Advancement

For the purposes of advancement (i.e. graduation from the upper level and advancement from the lower level to the upper), teacher evaluations included in the learning narrative document sufficient fluency in the school's subject-area competencies (see the Content Area and Completency Outline in our Curriculum Handbook for a sense of what we mean by "fluency").

Students in the upper level are also asked to select a small number of high-quality forms of external validation that complement their portfolios and reflect their intended path after graduation. For students planning to attend college, this will usually include the ACT and/or SAT, and might also include juried exhibitions, apprenticeship sign-offs, or externally validated rites of passage. Students also complete a capstone service-learning project in their final year in the upper level.

The school offers a highly tailored college admissions support program, as well as support for non-traditional post-secondary pathways, and offers a proven, high-quality approach to transcript documentation which draws on the evaluative components of the learning narrative.

Advancement requirements for the lower level are still under discussion. Perhaps above all, we are keen to ensure students have enough competency in project design and follow-through that they are able to take on the increased curricular responsibility that the upper level involves.

BEYOND THE CORE CURRICULUM

1. Play and Exploration

Students have ample time to pursue purely self-chosen, open-ended activities at Canoe Valley. The role of open-ended exploration and play–as rich sources of future student projects, as foundational modes of learning in their own right, and as essential supports for student wellbeing–is central to the school. Our school day aims to provide a healthy balance of open-ended learning opportunities involving play and exploration and the more structured ones found in our core curriculum (which itself includes plenty of room for play and exploration as well). Teachers protect the freedom of students to pursue their own learning goals during unstructured time, paying attention to students' developing interests to guide future teaching.

2. Electives

Electives allow students to develop skills, practices, and areas of knowledge they feel drawn toward, often

over a sustained period of time. Students collaborate with teachers to shape a living list of elective offerings that reflects emerging interests within the school community. Projects undertaken in elective classes may be used to satisfy competency pathway requirements. Community members who would like to offer an elective can join a pool of prospective Session Teachers, and may also offer their time as mentors or apprenticeship leaders.

3. Supplemental Programs in Reading and Math

The school provides two additional programs geared toward strong foundations in literacy and numeracy: a daily independent reading program and a math practice program, in both the lower and upper level. The reading program takes inspiration from the Book Whisperer model, focusing on fostering engagement through free choice, peer reading companions, teachers who serve as matchmakers between students and books, and a rich school library. The math program focuses on play, puzzles, games, and rich tasks, taking inspiration from Math for Love and the Julia Robertson Math Festival models.

4. Peer Learning

Students learn in mixed-age communities mirroring real-world social environments. Younger students contribute to collaborative projects with older peers and learn through participation in school culture. Older students deepen learning by modeling skills and taking on leadership roles. The school intentionally supports peer learning in a number of other ways, including a semester project collaboration requirement and a "trailheads and crossings" board where students and teachers post project ideas looking for collaborators.

5. Mentorship and Reflection

Students and teachers engage in 1-on-1 mentorship sessions providing educational, problem-solving, and emotional support. 1-on-1 mentorship is also the medium for teacher-student collaboration on project design and competency pathway check-ins.
Students and teachers also participate in weekly group circles that expand students' reflective work in 1-on-1 mentorship and in their learning narratives, and bring it into dialogue with others. We take inspiration from the circles of trust model and council practice, creating affirming spaces where students can joyfully risk being themselves, learn to listen deeply, and come to respect the difference and mystery of others.

6. School Culture and Community Life

Students and teachers participate in campus and farm stewardship and neighborhood stewardship activities that foster connection to place and a sense of shared responsibility to each other and to the land. (See our Sample Schedule, and our exciting site development plans below.)

Service-learning permeates much of the school's educational activity in light of our focus on place and our project-based approach. As often as possible, projects and other educational activities derive real-world stakes from engagement with the needs of our neighbors and the place we live.

A daily teacher-led gathering circle grounds the community in the present moment, marks seasonal change, and gives rhythm to the school day and year. Students participate in quarterly showcases where they present, perform, and/or exhibit project work to family members, teachers, and peers.

In the upper level, students participate in one or more self-chosen school committees that support the academic and operational life of the school and function as the primary mode of internal governance (an important form of service-learning in its own right!). Examples include Curriculum, Campus and Facilities, Culture, and Marketing and Development committees. Students, Teachers, and all who join us on campus abide by a culture agreement that ensures a healthy and safe learning environment for all.

7. Co-Curricular Activities: Apprenticeships, Expeditions, and more

Students and teachers participate in an expeditionary learning program designed to strengthen self- and relational trust, cooperation, interdependence, and group meaning-making (the details of this program, including how often expeditions might take place, e.g. annual, are currently under discussion).

Students have the opportunity to pursue both campus-based and offsite apprenticeships in areas of interest, especially in the upper level, and to connect with community members who serve as apprenticeship leaders to deepen learning in a particular area. Apprenticeships, alongside traditional co-curricular activities like student clubs and service learning opportunities, are treated with the same emphasis as other components of the curriculum, and may be used satisfy competency pathway requirements.
Large-scale extracurricular activities like athletics, band, choir, and orchestra may be offered through the Decorah Community School District pending an agreement with DCSD.

8. Inclusion

The whole-person learning program outlined here provides clear paths to cultivating a welcoming and inclusive school campus, especially in terms of our focus on self-affirmation, expression, relationality, and respect for difference. We believe schools thrive when students feel safe being themselves, and when curriculum and teaching is responsive to differences in students' unique lived experiences, abilities, and ways of seeing the world. Our individualized, relational curriculum focuses on inclusion not just as an add-on, but supports all students' authentic self-expression and full participation in the life of the school as core parts of our learning program.

Partnerships

We'll have exciting details to share soon about partnerships, including with ReRooted Connections and Red Oak Outdoor School!

Sample Schedule

8:00-8:25 Arrival

8:30-9:50 Gathering Circle

Opening Block - Community Life: September thru Mid-October and Mid-April thru May

Campus & Farm Stewardship (e.g. harvest, planting, building projects, trail and grounds maintenance) - 'A' Week.

Neighborhood Stewardship (e.g. watershed care, community building projects, invasive species removal, lend-a-hand) - 'B' Week.

Opening Block - Inner Life: Mid-October thru mid-April

Independent Reading/Companion Reading/Book Clubs - 50min every day.

'Math for Love'-style Math Practice - 30min Monday Wednesday Friday.

Contemplative / Mindfulness-Based Practice - 30min Tuesday Thursday.

9:50-10:00 Break

10:00-12:15 Core Curriculum Block

Interdisciplinary, multi-age, adaptable projects on 3-4 week cycles with supporting teacher-led educational experiences (mini-lessons, demonstrations) in core subject areas. Two projects may sometimes be active at a time–for instance cycling shorter-duration projects while a longer one comes to fruition–but generally not more than that. See Content Area and Competency Outline and Sample Projects sections of this document. See also Documenting Learning and Advancement.

First 2-3 weeks of September: Mini-course in Project-Based Learning.

12:15-12:45 Lunch
12:45-3:00 Self-Directed Block

Exploration and Play - Every day.

Electives - 2:00-3:00 Monday Tuesday Wednesday Thursday, 1:00-3:00 Friday. Under discussion whether to include a requirement for a certain number of elective hours per semester, or make electives completely optional.

1-on-1 Mentorship - 15min per student Monday Tuesday.

Group Mentorship/Reflection/Teambuilding - Friday lunch.

Committee Activities - Asynchronous.

Co-Curriculars (Apprenticeships, Clubs) - Asynchronous.

3:00-3:15 Cleanup/Day Ends